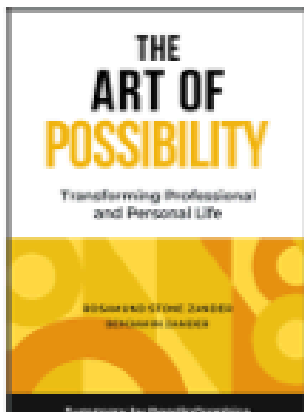




THE ART OF POSSIBILITY

Transforming Professional and Personal Life

ROSAMUND STONE ZANDER & BENJAMIN ZANDER

The Big “So What”



When you're stuck with a seemingly-impossible problem, the best way to get unstuck is to shift your perspective. In this book, the authors combine their knowledge and experience as a conductor and a therapist, to present 12 practices that you can use to see new possibilities and bring them to life. By applying these principles and tools over time, you can transform your results and relationships.

However, to reconstruct how you perceive the world, you must first be willing to challenge your beliefs and assumptions, and to keep applying the practices until the new ways of thinking and behaving become intuitive to you.

The 12 Possibility Practices



Practice #1: Realize that Everything is Invented



Everything we know is actually filtered through our mental stories. You pick up selective info about the environment via your 5 senses (e.g. your nose picks up a scent). Your brain interprets the info before you have a conscious experience (“I smell oranges!”). By the time you’re conscious of something, your brain has already gone through a complex process of info-selection, cue-matching and story-telling.



Our perceptions are always flawed:

- All living creatures are hardwired to “see” the world in a way that helps them survive. A frog’s eye “sees” differently from the human eye. It sees the world in terms of moving outlines and sudden changes in light (which helps it to react to insects and predators), but it cannot perceive the beauty of the sunset or appreciate a field of colorful flowers.

KEY QUOTES

“The objective of this book is to provide the reader the means to lift off from that world of struggle and sail into a vast universe of possibility.”

“It takes dedication, a leap of faith, and, yes, practicing to get them into your repertoire.”

“All of life comes to us in narrative form; it's a story we tell.”

“The world comes into our consciousness in the form of a map already drawn, a story already told, a hypothesis, a construction of our own making.”

Likewise, human senses are limited—we don't see/sense everything, e.g. we can't see molecular traces like insects do, or pick up scents the way dogs do.

- We also use mental maps (theories and beliefs) to make sense of what's going on. We can't recognize things that aren't on our mental map, e.g. you won't recognize the smell of oranges if you've never seen/tasted one, and you won't realize you're affected by gravity if you haven't learned about it.
- Our brains also tend to connect events, people and ideas into stories even if there are no direct links (e.g. if we see someone eating a dish with gusto, we conclude that it tastes good).



The first practice is simply to recognize that everything is invented, including what we think is a truth or fact.

- Even science isn't absolute. Scientific truths evolve as new discoveries are made. Newton helped us to see the world in terms of straight lines and forces, while Einstein helped us to see the world in terms of curves, space/time and relativity. Like gravity, all these phenomena have always existed, yet we couldn't "see" them until we've made the paradigm shifts.
- So, instead of insisting that what you know is the absolute, unchanging truth, realize that it's all invented. A seemingly-insurmountable problem can usually be resolved if you approach it from another angle. Once you recognize the self-imposed frames and boxes you've put around yourself, you can start to reinvent them to improve your life.
- Keep asking yourself these questions:
 - (i) What unconscious assumptions am I making that lead me to see/ believe what I do?
 - (ii) What new assumptions can I adopt to give me new options?



KEY QUOTES

"The frames our minds create define—and confine—what we perceive to be possible."

"Each new paradigm gives us the opportunity to "see" phenomena that were before as invisible to us as the colors of the sunset to the frog."

"It's all invented anyway, so we might as well invent a story or a framework of meaning that enhances our quality of life and the life of those around us."

"Every problem, every dilemma, every dead end we find ourselves facing in life, only appears unsolvable inside a particular frame or point of view. Enlarge the box, or create another frame around the data, and problems vanish, while new opportunities appear."



Practice #2: Move from Scarcity to Abundance



We live in a “world of measurement” where everything is evaluated against goals, standards, and comparisons.

- Underlying all human struggles—our fears, doubts and disappointments—is the hidden assumption that we must fight to survive in a world of scarcity and danger.
- This leads us to constantly watch for danger, build our reserves, and maintain our defences. We constantly measure where we stand and evaluate things/people by measuring, comparing and contrasting them against one another.



What if you were to change this fundamental assumption and step into a world of possibility?

- The key is to differentiate between scarcity vs scarcity-thinking. Even if you truly face scarcity and threats to your survival (e.g. you're living in a poor, war-torn area), you're still free to create infinite possibilities using your creativity and resourcefulness. Unfortunately, the reverse is true in most cases—people who're well-do-to are plagued by scarcity-thinking. They *think* the world is out to get them, so they hog resources and keep grabbing more and more to create real scarcity in the process.
- Scarcity-thinking assumes that the pie gets smaller each time you take something. On the other hand, abundance-thinking assumes the pie is unlimited and you can add to the pie each time you receive from it. For example, businesses don't have to compete for a finite pool of customers; they can generate infinite new ideas to create new customers. With an abundance-mindset, you're likely to give more, create and add value, thus generate *real* growth and abundance.



Learn to let go of the need to measure and judge everything:

- Ask yourself: How do my current thoughts and actions reflect the world of measurement? Look for signs of competition, comparison, anxiety, or fear of survival/scarcity.

KEY QUOTES

“It feels safer to deal with reality as though it were fixed, as though people, ideas, and situations can be fully known and measured.”

“Free from the generalized assumption of scarcity, a person stands in the great space of possibility in a posture of openness, with an unfettered imagination for what can be.”



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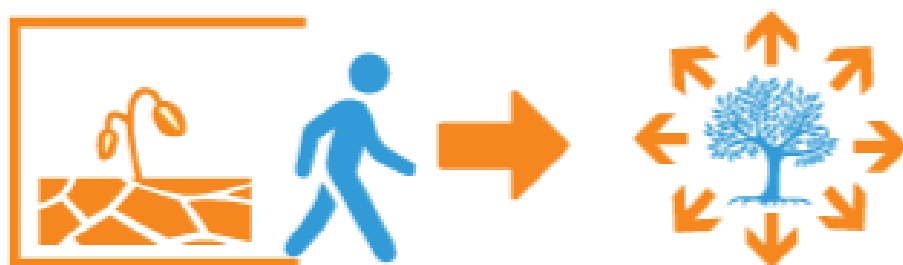
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- Reframe your thoughts and ask the same question over and over, until you realize how ridiculous it is to keep measuring and judging everything. Make a decision to let go and step into a new world of possibilities.



Practice #3: Gift an A



We tend to grade people (literally or mentally) and use that grade to define their abilities/potential. In reality, grades often don't mean much; a C-grader in a top school could actually be doing much better than an A-grader in another school. Just like how a carver recognizes the potential of an uncut stone, the role of any leader—be it a teacher, manager or parent—is to bring out the potential of the person in front of you.

- In Ben's class on musical performance, he told every student from the onset that he'd give them an "A" for the course. The only condition was, they had to write a letter (dated 1 year later) to describe in detail what they'd done over the year to get the grade. As the students described their milestones, achievements and feelings, they got a vision of the A students they could be, while Ben felt motivated to groom a class of A students.
- When the students made a mistake, Ben encouraged them to exclaim, "How fascinating!", then take a closer look to see what could be learned from the experience.



Obviously, grades and actual performance are important. The crux of this practice is to realize that all standards (be it grades or ranking) are man-made. We can choose to use standards to create possibilities instead of label/judge people.

- Treat standards as a common goal to work toward (between a student and teacher, or a manager and staff), rather than an assessment of someone's ability.
- The fastest way to "change" someone is to change your own perception. Every human being has an innate desire to

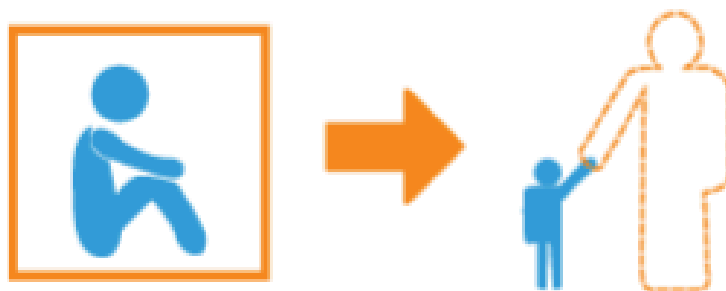
KEY QUOTES

"In the measurement world, you set a goal and strive for it. In the universe of possibility, you set the context and let life unfold."

"This A is not an expectation to live up to, but a possibility to live into."

contribute and make a difference. When people believe they're A Graders are more likely work hard and persevere to deliver results. When you give someone an "A", you're more likely to notice their positive qualities and accept their inputs, thus creating a partnership that delivers real results.

- Likewise, when you give yourself an "A", you're accepting yourself as you are, and not because you've achieved certain outcomes or standards.
- In short, when you give an "A" to people as a gift (not as a gauge of what they've done or who they are), you open up a new world of possibilities for yourself and others.



Practice #4: Be a Contribution



Most of us are constantly judging everything we do. We try to achieve "success" and avoid "failure", only to feel stressed and dissatisfied as no amount of achievement seems to be enough. Why should a positive contribution be labelled as a success or failure based on an invented target or standard?



Try thinking of your life as a series of games instead. You're free to choose which games to play, and you're free to move on to a new game any time.



To transform your struggles into fulfilling experiences, redefine yourself as a contribution, i.e. someone who makes a difference.

- Ask yourself: "How can I be a contribution today?". Just focus on making a difference, without worrying about how much you've achieved or whether you're good enough.
- Try writing down everything you've done in the past week that contributed to someone (e.g. helping a blind man to cross the road, running an errand for your parents). Imagine how each contribution may have created further ripple effects.

KEY QUOTES

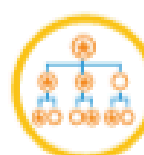
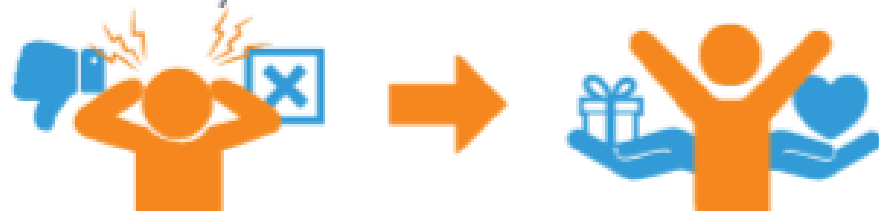
"The practice of giving the A allows the teacher to line up with her students in their efforts to produce the outcome, rather than lining up with the standards against these students."

"The freely granted A expresses a vision of partnership, teamwork, and relationship."

"The drive to be successful and the fear of failure are, like the head and tail of a coin, inseparably linked."

"In the game of contribution you wake up each day and bask in the notion that you are a gift to others."

In the next week, take note of every contribution you make without judging how much or little it is. By shifting your focus away from your own problems to the positive contribution you're making, you reduce your anxiety and increase the satisfaction from your activities.

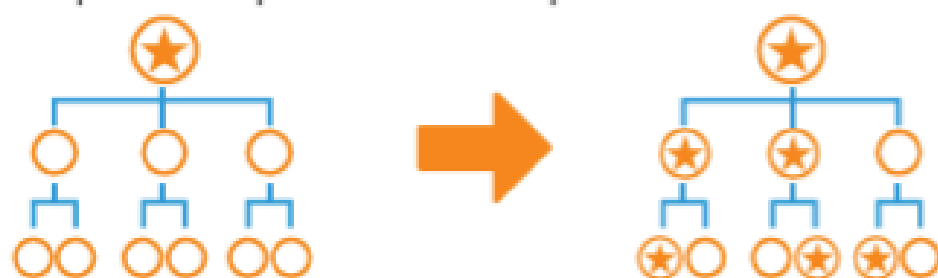


Practice #5: Lead from Any Position

In most orchestras, the conductor dictates how the music should be interpreted, and the players have little/no room to influence the direction of the music.

- Ben believes that a great conductor should coax the best possible music from his orchestra, even if the music is interpreted differently from conductor's original idea. To empower every musician to play as beautifully as possible, he asked them to write down how he could enable them to play better. As the players suggest alternative ways to conduct and interpret the music, the orchestra's music was elevated to a new level.
- In 1999, the Youth Philharmonic Orchestra from USA and the National Youth Orchestra of Cuba did a combined performance. Each conductor was struggling to coach the other orchestra on their chosen music piece. They finally overcame the challenge by having each player guide his/her counterpart instead of using a top-down approach.

In a large group, there'll always be people who can offer talents and insights if they're given the chance to do so. This practice is about finding and unlocking the hidden passion and commitment that exists in every person. When you see a listless, dispirited team member, you can assume the person is unmotivated, or you can take it upon yourself to find out what it'll take to bring out the spark and passion in that person.



KEY QUOTES

"In the music business, as in all walks of life, a leader who feels he is superior is likely to suppress the voices of the very people on whom he must rely to deliver his vision alive and kicking."

"A conductor's true power derives from his ability to make other people powerful."

"A monumental question for leaders in any organization to consider is: How much greatness are we willing to grant people?"

"A leader does not need a podium; she can be sitting quietly on the edge of any chair, listening passionately and with commitment, fully prepared to take up the baton...the leader may be any one of us."



Practice #6: Lighten Up

! All of us have a “calculating self” that’s constantly on the lookout for perceived threats, trying to prove ourselves and ensure we don’t lose out in a world of scarcity.

- When we feel threatened, we instinctively try to assert control or defend ourselves. We lash out and make demands, only to start a downward spiral that locks us in conflict, competition or impasse.
- Humor and laughter help us to stop taking ourselves too seriously. When we loosen up, others also relax and the negative spiral is broken. During a long, exhausting music practice, Ben instructed the players to stop making mistakes. Sensing the immediate tension in the room, he quickly added, “If you make a mistake...a five-hundred-pound cow will fall on your head.” Everyone laughed, lightened up and played better after that.
- In the end, our own fears, views and positions are the real obstacles that stand in the way of a rewarding experience. Ask yourself: “What would have to change for me to be completely fulfilled?” When you let go of your self-imposed expectations and rules, the things that previously bothered you may suddenly disappear. For example, you may have become defensive because you felt judged by your spouse. Once you relax and focus on other aspects of the relationship, things may improve naturally.

💡 When you lighten up, your calculative self weakens its hold to allow your “central self” to shine through. This is your authentic self that’s creative, whole and abundant.

- Your central self recognizes how your own pride and indignation can get in the way of your desired outcomes. Once you realize the source of your fears and concerns, you can explore new ways to address them.
- Two business partners were stuck in a stalemate over their contract. They had complementary strengths needed for the business, but were too entrenched in their own positions to

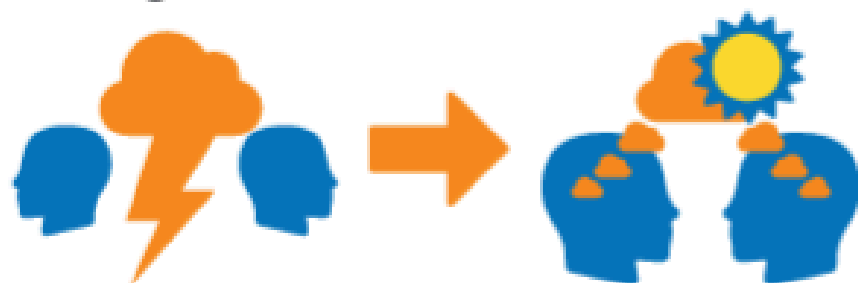
KEY QUOTES

“When...we coax this calculating self to lighten up...we break its hold on us.”

“Human beings are social animals; we move in a dance with each other, we are all fundamentally immeasurable, we all belong.”

“When one person peels away layers of opinion, entitlement, pride, and inflated self-description, others instantly feel the connection.”

consider alternatives. Roz managed to draw out a few common truths, e.g. one of the partners had failed to deliver on his promise while the other had been overly rigid with the contractual terms. Once their central selves could see how their calculative selves were getting in the way of a mutually-beneficial contract, it opened up the way for a proper dialogue to address each other's concerns.



Practice #7: See the Way Things Are

 Have you ever felt resigned that there's nothing you can do because "that's just the way things are"?

- This practice is about becoming present to (i) what's truly happening and (ii) your own reactions to them, so you get clear on your circumstances and what you can do to move toward your desired outcomes.
- Imagine you arrive at the airport full of anticipation for your long-awaited ski vacation, only to find that the flight has been delayed indefinitely due to a snowstorm. You can rant and rave about how unfair it is (which will change nothing). Or, you can acknowledge your disappointment with the delay and uncertainty, then shift your attention to what you can do, e.g. use the time to rest, enjoy a nice meal, or research alternative travel options.

 Don't resist what is. Instead, gather the facts of the situation so you can decide what to do with it. This requires that you learn to discern between facts, feelings and assumptions.

- Listen for "shoulds". When you feel frustrated because things are not how they *should* be, it's a clear sign of resistance.
- Resist blame/denial. When you're experiencing something unpleasant, don't deny your feelings, run away from the problem, or blame others. If you do so, you'll just be stuck with the very things you don't want.

KEY QUOTES

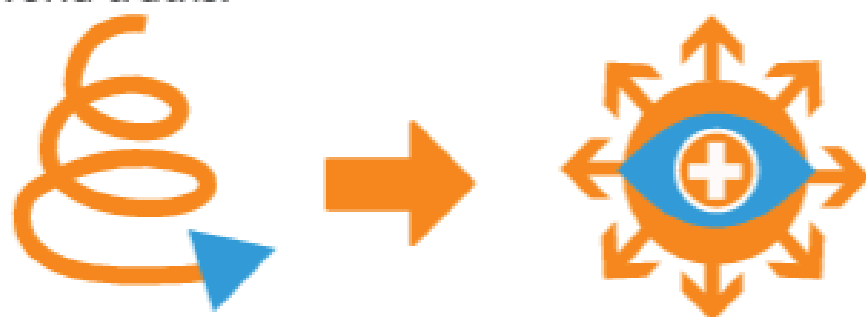
"The capacity to be present to everything that is happening, without resistance, creates possibility."

"The more attention you shine on a particular subject, the more evidence of it will grow."

- Realize that nothing is purely good or bad, e.g. the flight delay may shorten your trip but lead you to your future spouse.

Shift from downward spirals to possibility talk.

- Avoid downward spiral talk, i.e. speaking as if things are doomed to get worse. What we focus on grows—the more you focus on scarcity and problems, the more you'll notice them. When you make statements like "the barrier between my husband and I is getting worse", your brain will pick out evidence that supports the statement, and things will indeed seem to get worse. Instead, stop and refocus on the facts of what happened or what is happening, e.g. "We used to tell each other about our day. Nowadays I don't ask about his day and he doesn't volunteer information." Or "I feel irritated when my husband doesn't look at me when I talk to him."
- Once you can see things as they are, including your own biases, fears and imagined reality, you can expand your viewpoint and explore possibilities built on facts and reality. Martin Luther King Jr's "I have a dream" speech is an example of how you can speak in possibility grounded in real-world truths.



Practice #8: Flow with Passion

-  We tend to see the objects/people around us as separate entities, which creates artificial barriers. In reality, energy flows all around us and through us; it moves freely and isn't limited to rigid forms or lines.

 This practice is about giving in fully to the creative energy waiting to be expressed through you.

- If a musician or presenter is obsessed with the way he stands, how he looks and whether each word/note is technically perfect, he'll deliver a stiff performance. On the other hand,

KEY QUOTES

"Abstractions that we unwittingly treat as physical reality tend to block us from seeing the way things are, and therefore reduce our power to accomplish what we say we want."

"Speaking in possibility springs from the appreciation that what we say creates a reality; how we define things sets a framework for life to unfold."

"Life takes on shape and meaning when a person is able to transcend the barriers of personal survival and become a unique conduit for its vital energy."

someone who's prepared to lose himself in the passion of the moment is much more likely to capture the audience's imagination.

- Become aware of the imaginary boundaries that hold you back (e.g. your public image, fear of disapproval). Allow those lines to be blurred and flow with your inner passions and vitality.



Practice #9: Ignite the Spark



It's untrue that you can only persuade others through manipulation or some form of exchange. In a world of possibility, persuasion can be as simple as giving people an "A" and being prepared to ask, give and receive freely. This practice is about enrolling people by igniting their imagination and bringing out their passion.

- Start by believing that others are ready to be enrolled by you, while being open to be inspired by them. Then, make your requests/offers with the conviction that they'll catch the spark.
- Roz needed 2 quarters to fill her flat tyre, but she only had a \$10 bill and no one nearby had enough change for \$10. In a flash of inspiration, she asked if one of them could give her 2 quarters instead. She got the 2 quarters she needed and the stranger who gave it to her felt good about making a difference.
- Ben was trying to get a sponsorship from Arthur Anderson for the Philharmonia Orchestra of London. Arthur Anderson, on the other hand, wanted to make a positive impact with Eastlea School (a "failing" school in a bleak part of London). Both sides were infected by each other's passion and came up with the idea of introducing the Eastlea students to classical music. Despite scepticism that the Eastenders wouldn't appreciate such music, the program turned out to

KEY QUOTES

"Release those barriers of self that keep you separate and in control, and let the vital energy of passion surge through you, connecting you to all beyond."

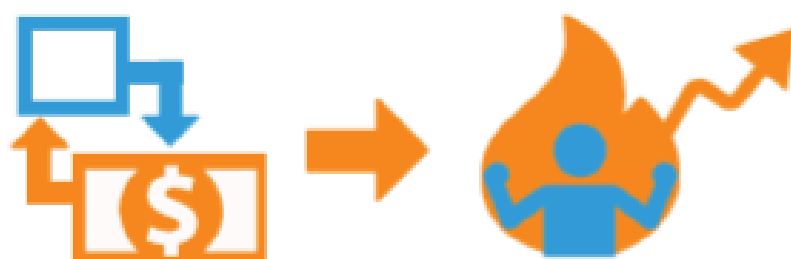
"Enrolling is not about forcing, cajoling, tricking, bargaining, pressuring, or guilt-tripping someone into doing something your way. Enrollment is the art and practice of generating a spark of possibility for others to share."

"The life force for humankind is, perhaps, nothing more or less than the passionate energy to connect, express, and communicate."

be a huge success—the students were inspired and uplifted by the music, and the public saw an attentive, insightful side of the students they hadn't expected.



Passion is a great cure for fear and doubt. Appeal to passion and abundance (not fear and scarcity) as a source of motivation.



Practice #10: Be the Chessboard



When people act differently from our expectations or break certain "rules", we're quick to blame them for disrupting our sense of order and control, without considering our own roles in the situation. This practice is about shifting an external problem into yourself to see things from a fresh perspective.

- In chess, we typically think of how to move the pieces according to our strategy. When you think of yourself as the chessboard, you'll simply accommodate all possible moves instead of trying to control them. This gives you freedom, not because you can control the conditions, but because you can *choose* how you experience those conditions and respond to them.
- Let's imagine you're crossing the road when you're injured by a car that didn't stop in time. Legally, the driver is at fault since you started crossing after the lights turned green. However, instead of blaming the driver or fate, you can acknowledge your own role in the event. Just by being on the road, you created the context for the accident. You may also have been looking at your phone or assumed it was safe to cross without checking for oncoming vehicles. This does not mean that you're to blame or that you shouldn't seek recompense from the driver. Being the board simply helps you to see things more objectively so you can take enlightened actions.

KEY QUOTES

"Passion, rather than fear, is the igniting force."

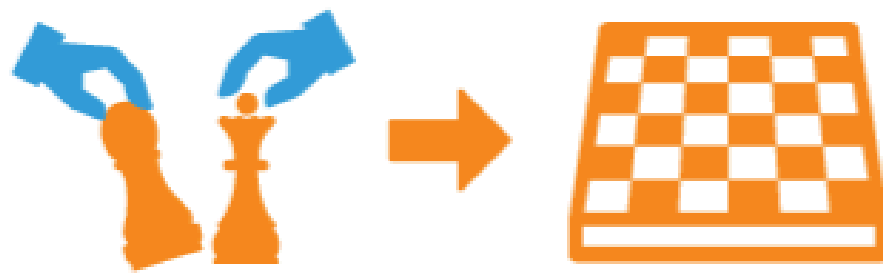
"When you are being the board, you present no obstacles to others. You name yourself as the instrument to make all your relationships into effective partnerships."

"Grace comes from owning the risks we take in a world by and large immune to our control."



Fundamentally, this practice is not about exerting control; it's about making a positive difference.

- When you shift your attention away from blame and what things *should* be, you free yourself to explore new possibilities. Define yourself as the board, examine how a situation landed on your board, and focus on how to make a difference.
- For example, you may be upset that you can't get your boss to listen to your suggestions. Instead of blaming him (for being arrogant or a poor listener) or blaming yourself (for being useless and unpersuasive), step back to consider how you may have contributed to his unwillingness to listen. Then evaluate what you can do to move things forward.



KEY QUOTES

"Once you do transform your experience and see things differently, other changes occur."



Practice #11: Create Possibility Frameworks



Leaders play a critical role in shifting people's focus away from scarcity/downward spirals, and toward possibilities/abundance instead. This practice is about generating options by restructuring meaning, developing visions and creating environments that support possibilities.



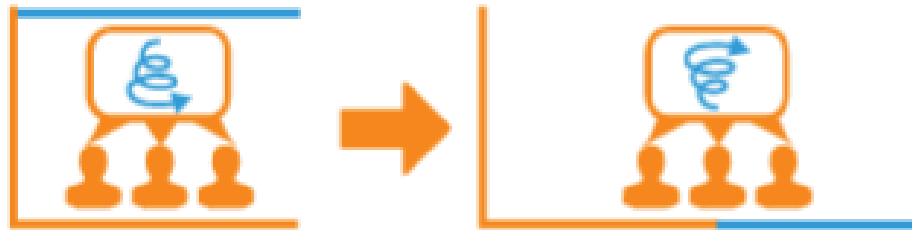
Define an alternative that can stop an existing downward spiral, then embody the vision to give new meaning to an existing action/event.

- When someone does something "wrong", our instinctive response is to punish the person, which only starts a downward spiral. A better approach is to ask: "How else can I approach the situation to inspire desired behaviors through possibility?"
- A leukaemia patient became the laughing stock of her class after she shaved her head due to chemotherapy. The teacher didn't defend the girl or reprimand her classmates.

She simply came to school one day sporting a shaved head. Soon, the kids in school were cutting their hair or shaving their heads as a fashion statement. By shaving her head, the teacher had reframed what it meant to look different and catalysed new behaviors.

 When you articulate a strong vision, you're painting a common future that people can relate to.

- A great vision (e.g. "world peace", "bringing joy to everyday living"), is timeless and doesn't require benchmarks or a "right" way of doing things. It removes barriers and creates a new realm of possibility for everyone.
- You can still set goals when pursuing vision-led objectives. However, missing a goal won't kill your vision. Just declare "how fascinating!" and keep moving forward.



Practice #12: Focus on WE

 An "us-vs-them" mentality promotes conflict because it assumes the differences (between religions, ideologies etc.) are irreconcilable. In such cases, "we" is defined as "You + I". The parties are seen as separate entities with different and unchanging desires, so if one party wins the other party must lose. Both sides end up fighting fiercely to protect their rights, positions and viewpoints.

 The WE practice is about (i) identifying what connects people, (ii) listening/looking out for what emerges and (iii) jointly defining what WE want and the best thing to do for US. Start by defining every human as someone who desires to contribute and connect with others—this focuses your attention on what connects people rather than what separates them.

- Assume that WE are 1 entity, and there *can* be a direction where WE can move together to jointly define and achieve new goals.

KEY QUOTES

"A vision is a long line of possibility radiating outward. It invites infinite expression, development, and proliferation within its definitional framework."

"In the pursuit of objectives under a vision, playing is relevant to the manifestation of the possibility, winning is not."

- For example, instead of saying “If you don’t give me a pay raise, I’ll quit”, you could take a WE approach: “We both seem to agree that I’ve been delivering good work. Unfortunately, the salary isn’t enough to support my present commitments. What do WE want to see happen, and how can WE make it work?”



Separate your central selves from your calculating selves. Make your pride, greed, revenge, fear or sense of righteousness as the common enemy instead of each other. You can acknowledge, “OK, that was my Pride speaking” then focus on how to tackle the villain Pride together, instead of attacking each other.

- At the end of apartheid in South Africa, Mandela’s government instituted the Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC). The TRC didn’t dish out justice to people involved in the violence, but offered amnesty to those who’d share the truth. As the perpetrators shared their stories and the atrocities they committed, people saw their pain and how they broke down in tears. Instead of focusing on blame, revenge and justice, the TRC helped people to realize there wasn’t a definitive line between “victim” and “perpetrator”. It helped people to understand their past so they could heal and build a new future together.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For



This is not intended as a guidebook with answers for specific real-world problems. Instead, the 12 practices in the book (along with the various stories, letters and reflections) equip you with alternative perspectives and approaches to face *any* challenge in life, and design the stage upon which you’d express yourself and discover life’s unlimited possibilities.

KEY QUOTES

“The WE appears when, for the moment, we set aside the story of fear, competition, and struggle, and tell its story.”

“The issues themselves are rarely what they seem, no matter what pains are taken to verify the scoreboard.”